



Subversion

Version Compatibility

Here's some advice on choosing the right release of Subversion.

The toughest job for any server administrator is to choose the correct version of software to install and use for maintenance. Most server software have corresponding clients that access the software to get data from them. This kind of client-server model creates a few problems when a server administrator is trying to choose the right version of server software.

In this article, we will discuss one such problem in choosing the appropriate release of the popular version control system, Subversion. This article will also help decipher version compatibility among most of the free software available.

Servers

All the Subversion servers that have the same major version number will be compatible with each other. For example, if you are using Subversion 1.6.3 and want to switch to 1.6.x, which is greater than 1.6.3, both are compatible without any modifications. On the other hand, when you want to switch from 1.5.x to 1.6.x server, there may be some difference in the repository *backend/fsfs/bdb*, for which

the Subversion community provides tools to make this upgrade smooth without any problems. The Subversion servers that have a major version number will be compatible with all Subversion clients, which will have the same major version number.

Clients

When the minor version number (which is '6' in version 1.6.4) of a Subversion client changes, you'll typically notice more features added to the Subversion client, but without breaking the backward compatibility between the minor version numbers. In other words, none of the features available in the same minor version number series will be broken when we go for an upgrade. All the features in 1.5.x will continue to be available in 1.6.x along with some additional features.

The Subversion clients and servers will have sub minor version numbers such as the 4 in version 1.6.4. These sub minor versions are released with bug fixes. There is a good chance that these bug fixes are also back-ported to earlier releases, such as 1.5.x or 1.4.x, if these branches are still being maintained. But none of the features